

Session 16: Paul's View of the Powers

Key Takeaways

- In the New Testament, the powers are both heavenly and earthly, divine and human, spiritual and political, invisible and structural.
- Paul sees the cosmic rulers (spiritual beings) as being invested in the political, ethnic, gendered, and socioeconomic structures of our world.
- Paul sees spiritual beings as intimately connected to the earthly entities (rulers, social structures, etc.) who work to divide and corrupt what God has intended to unify.
- Enslavement to the powers is the human condition apart from the messianic hope.

Rulers, Authorities, Powers, and Dominions

The “rulers, authorities, powers, and dominions” are introduced in the first chapter of Ephesians ([Eph. 1:21](#)). Who or what are they?

The Heavenly/Spiritual Realm

In Ephesians, these powers exist in the parallel heavenly/spiritual realm, and evidence of their work is found in corporate human societies, institutions, and cultural ideologies.

Ephesians 1:20-21 Instructor's Translation

²⁰ Christ ... is seated at [God's] right hand in the heavenly realm, ²¹ far above all rule and authority, and power and dominion ... not only in this age, but also in the age to come.

Ephesians 2:2 Instructor's Translation

... the age of this world, the ruler of the authority of the air, the spirit who is now working among the sons of disobedience ...

Ephesians 3:10 NASB

... the rulers and authorities in the heavenly places.

Ephesians 6:12 Instructor's Translation

... not flesh and blood, but the rulers, authorities, the cosmic powers of this present darkness, the evil spiritual beings in the heavenly realm.

The Slanderer

In Paul's letter, the powers are related to, but distinct from, the role of "the satan" (the opposer), or "the devil" (the slanderer), who is said to influence people primarily on the individual and community level.

Ephesians 4:26-27 Instructor's Translation

²⁶ Don't let the sun go down on your anger, ²⁷ so you don't give a place to the slanderer.

The Influence of the Powers

In Paul's other letters, the influence of the powers is at work on a corporate level in social, political, cultural, and religious systems.

Colossians 1:16 Instructor's Translation

All things were created in him, things in the heavens and things on earth, the visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities, all things were created through him and for him.

Colossians 2:8 Instructor's Translation

They take you away captive through philosophies and empty deception, in accordance with human traditions and the elemental powers of the cosmos, not in accordance with the Messiah.

Colossians 2:15 Instructor's Translation

After disarming the rulers and authorities, he exposed them to public shame, triumphing over them in the Messiah.

Galatians 1:3-4 Instructor's Translation

³ ... Jesus Messiah, ⁴ who gave himself on behalf of our sins in order to rescue us from the present evil age.

Galatians 4:3 Instructor's Translation

We ... were enslaved under the elemental powers of the cosmos.

Galatians 4:8-9 Instructor's Translation

⁸ ... you were enslaved to what by nature were not gods. ⁹ ... the weak and impoverished elemental powers

1 Corinthians 2:6, 8 Instructor's Translation

⁶ ... the rulers of this age who are passing away; ... ⁸ the rulers of this age ... who, if they did know [the wisdom of God] they would not have crucified the Lord of glory.

1 Corinthians 15:24-26 Instructor's Translation

²⁴ When [the Messiah] hands over the kingdom to God and Father, when he nullifies every rule and authority and power, ²⁵ for it is necessary that he rule until he has placed all enemies under his feet; ²⁶ the last enemy to be nullified is death.

Romans 8:38-39 Instructor's Translation

³⁸ Neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers nor the present nor the future nor powers ... ³⁹ nor anything in all creation will be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Messiah Jesus our Lord.

The Satan

The devil ("slanderer"), or the satan ("the one opposed"), works on the individual and community level.

1 Thessalonians 2:18 NASB*

... we desired to come to you ... but the satan hindered us.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Thessalonians 3:5 Instructor's Translation

I sent to know more about your faithfulness, lest somehow the tester test you

Romans 16:20 NASB*

The God of peace is soon to crush the satan under y'all's [the Roman house churches] feet.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Concept of "The Powers" in the Wider New Testament

The Earthly Powers

John 12:31, 42 ESV*

³¹ Now is the judgment of this world, now the ruler (*archon*) of this world will be cast outside. ... ⁴² Nevertheless, even many of the rulers (*archontes*) believed in Jesus ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Luke 22:52-53 Instructor's Translation

⁵² Jesus said to the ruling priests (*arch-hiereis*) and commanders (*strategois*) of the temple and the elders,
⁵³ "... this is your hour, and of the authority (*exousia*) of darkness."

Romans 13:1 NIV*

Let every person submit themselves to the governing authorities (*exousiais*).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Romans 8:38-39 NASB*

³⁸ For I am convinced that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor rulers (*archon*), nor things present, nor things to come, nor powers (*dunamis*), ³⁹ nor height, nor depth, nor any other created thing, will be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Messiah Jesus our Lord.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These statements express a worldview in which the realities that we consider separate (spiritual vs. material) are unified and interconnected.

The Visible and Invisible

If you consider all of the uses of “power” vocabulary in the New Testament, you discover that the powers are both heavenly and earthly, divine and human, spiritual and political, invisible and structural.

Colossians 1:16 Instructor's Translation

For in [the messianic Son] all things were created, **things in the heavens and things on the earth**, things **visible** and things **invisible**, whether thrones or territories of dominion, whether rulers or authorities, all things were created by him and for him.

The parallelism makes clear that Paul saw these powers as both earthly and heavenly, visible and invisible, with manifestations that are both human and supra-human, material and non-material. This means that whenever the New Testament authors speak of power, they are referring to a power that is both of Heaven and Earth, material and spiritual.

Key Terms for Power

- *Archon/Arche*, ruler/rule: **A specific person** who is in a role of authorized authority, power, and widespread influence, mostly kings and officials of a monarchy or priests and officials of a temple
- *Exousia*, authority: **A structure or social arrangement** that is upheld and represented by an authorized person or group
- *Dunamis*, power: **The real or potential influence** manifest in military, political, or economic institutions or officials who represent them
- *Thronos*, throne: **The symbol of institutional or structural authority** or power associated with an institution (metaphorically refers to a structure of power, not a particular person)
- *Kuriotes*, dominion/lordship: **The sphere or territory of a ruler's power** or influence

Key Texts for Power

Key Pauline texts illuminate the reality of the powers.

1 Corinthians 2:6-8 NASB*

⁶ We [the apostles] speak of a wisdom among those who are mature; a wisdom, however, not of this age nor of the **rulers of this age**, who are passing away; ⁷ rather, we speak of God's wisdom, the open-secret which has been hidden, which God predestined before the ages for our exaltation to glory; ⁸ [a wisdom] that none of the **rulers of this age** understood; for if they had understood it they would not have crucified the Lord of glory.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The New Testament is clear that it was human rulers (*archon*) that crucified Jesus. “The chief priests (*archiereis*) and rulers (*archon*) delivered Jesus over to death and crucified him” (Luke 24:20). So at the very least, 1 Corinthians 2:6-8 includes Jewish and Roman religious, military, and political leaders and the institutions they represent (the temple and the empire).

However, to call Caiaphas and Pilate “the rulers of this age,” that is, of this entire world order, is extreme. Additionally, none of them were still in office when Paul wrote to the Corinthians. He speaks of these powers in the present as still existing.

Later, when Paul speaks of Jesus’ death and resurrection, he again mentions the powers in 1 Corinthians 15:24-26.

1 Corinthians 15:24-26 NASB*

²⁴ Then [will come] the completion, when [Messiah] hands over the kingdom to the God and Father, when he has disempowered all **rule** (*arche*) and all **authority** (*exousia*) and **power** (*dunamis*). ²⁵ For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. ²⁶ The last enemy that will be disempowered is death.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The key verb “disempowered” (*katargeo*) does not mean “destroy” (as in the ESV, NRSV, and NIV); rather, it means “neutralize” and/or “make null and void” (see [1 Cor. 1:28](#); [Eph. 2:15](#); [Rom. 4:14](#)). Paul’s point is that every human and cosmic structure of authority governing human existence in this current age of death and decay will have to be subdued in order to make way for the new creation.

Literary Design of Romans 8:35-39

³⁵ Who will separate us from the love of Christ?

Human Powers

^{35b} Will tribulation, or distress,
or persecution, or famine,
or nakedness, or peril, or sword?

³⁶⁻³⁷ Just as it is written,
“For your sake we are being put to death all day long;
we were considered as sheep to be slaughtered.”
But in all these things we overwhelmingly conquer through him who loved us.

Cosmic Powers

^{38-39a} For I am convinced that
not death, not life,
not angels, not rulers (*archon*),
not things present, not things to come,
not powers (*dunamis*),
not height, nor depth,

not any other creature,

39b will be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Romans 8:35-39. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

The rhetorical logic is that no creature in God's world, however rebellious and hostile to his purposes, can overpower the divine love expressed by the death and resurrection of Jesus. The hostile powers include human violence and opposition but also the corresponding cosmic powers who are responsible for suffering and death on a corporate, structural level. Notice that the cosmic powers in particular are called "creatures," that is, they have a proper role in God's world, though they are presently alienated from that role in their attempt to separate people from the creator's love.

Ephesians 1:20-23 NASB*

²⁰ [God] brought about in the Messiah, when he raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenlies, ²¹ far above all **rule** (*archon*) and **authority** (*exousia*) and **power** (*dunamis*) and **dominion** (*kuriotes*), and every name that is named, not only in this age but also in the one to come. ²² And he put all things in subjection under his feet, and gave him as head over all things to the church, ²³ which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Messiah's heavenly rule is not only over the cosmic/heavenly powers, because Paul specifies that all powers, which includes Heaven and Earth (Col. 1:16), are placed under his rule.

The image of the risen Jesus at God's right hand is derived from a combination of Psalm 8 and Psalm 110 (see Mark 14:62 and Matt. 28:18).

The Powers in Paul's Worldview

"In Paul's first-century worldview, nothing in heaven can happen without profound repercussions on earth; indeed, that is the way true change on earth is brought about. Nor would the message of peace in heaven constitute much 'good news' for those seeking deliverance here on earth. No, the use of 'all ... every ... all things' here is uncompromising in its breadth. No human or cosmic power in this world or the world to come is exempted."

Adapted from Wink, Walter (1984). [*Naming the Powers: The Language of Power in the New Testament*](#). Fortress Press. 60.

"If Christ is lord not only of persons but also of the powers, if his sovereignty extends beyond the individual to the social structures and spiritual influences that organize the world, it also extends to the very constituent principles of the physical universe itself, encompassing what we call the 'laws of nature.' This is what leads Paul to the phrase from Isaiah, 'new creation.'"

Adapted from Wink, Walter (1984). [Naming the Powers: The Language of Power in the New Testament](#). Fortress Press.

"[I]t is probable that Paul means by principalities and powers those institutions and structures by which earthly matters and invisible realms are administered, and without which no human life is possible. The superior power of nature epitomized by life and death; the ups and downs of historic processes; the nature and impact of favored prototypes or the catastrophic burdens of the past; the hope or threat offered to the present by the future; the might of capitalists, rulers, judges; the benefit and onus of laws of tradition and custom; the distinction and similarity of political and religious practices; the weight of ideologies and prejudices; the conditions under which all authority, labor, parenthood, etc., thrive or are crushed—these structures and institutions are in Paul's mind ... God's creation obviously does not consist of earthly-visible things alone. Just as [Genesis 1:1](#) treats the creation of the heavens and the earth, so also in Colossians 1:16 'invisible things in heavens' are added to those that are tangible. In the latter verse, either both or only the invisible things are identified with the powers. It is probable that in Ephesians Paul had in mind at the same time both visible, specific governors and the invisible authority exerted by them; concrete conditions and manifestations of life and the invisible mystery of the psyche; specific legal acts and the overarching role of law in general, etc. According to [Ephesians 1:10](#), both the heavenly and the earthly entities are subjected to Christ. Only when both are affected is the whole creation changed."

Barth, Markus (1974). [Ephesians 1-3](#). Doubleday & Co. 174-175.

"Paul considers the celestial bodies (also called 'the elements' in [Galatians 4:1-8](#)), to be personalized spiritual forces of some kind, supernatural beings that hold power over human beings ... [he] has in mind the tribal deities that were thought to oversee the nations on behalf of God (as in [Deut 32:8-9](#)) ... but this purpose deteriorated. These same regulating beings are what is meant in Ephesians as *kosmokratoras* ([Eph 6:12](#)), 'cosmic rulers.' But the metaphor in this word contains an ambiguity. On the one hand, they can be said to 'hold' (*krateo*) the world (*kosmos*), administering justice and order on behalf of God; on the other hand, their holding might easily become a 'grab' (*krateo*), in which they seek to detract attention from the true creator God and establish themselves as the ultimate in divine power and authority ... These are the 'spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places' ([Eph 6:11-12](#))."

Longenecker, Bruce (1998). [The Triumph of Abraham's God: The Transformation of Identity in Galatians](#). Abingdon Press. 49, 54-55.

"The complex structures of our societies set limits to what we can see, understand, and choose to do. We are caught in the web of relationships, expectations, economies, cultural activities, acculturation to particular contexts, political and administrative arrangements which seem seem to take on a life of their own, larger and more enduring, and more resistant than the efforts of any individual or group of individuals to change or act in opposition to such forces. Here then is the concrete presence of the 'sin' which Paul describes, the force for evil that precedes the choices of those who appear to be choosing, preempts the actions of those who appear to be acting, and tends to crush out of existence any who persist in acting in critical opposition."

Domning, Daryl P. and Hellwig, Monika K. (2006). [Original Selfishness: Original Sin and Evil in the Light of Evolution](#). Routledge. 16.

Paul envisions these cosmic rulers, or elemental powers, as spiritual beings invested in (what we call) the political, ethnic, gender, and socioeconomic structures that divide humans and assign greater or lesser value to various groups, resulting in corporate and individual sin, oppression, and injustice. In Galatians, Ephesians, Colossians, and Romans, it is these powers that have been conquered and overcome in the exaltation of the crucified Messiah.

“Paul’s vision of the ultimate rescue of the entire created order ... a vision which flowed directly from what he believed about the Messiah, impelled him to understand ‘evil’ as a whole which was more than the sum total of humans sins or deaths. Rather, ‘sin’ and ‘death’ were themselves suprahuman forces bent on corrupting and destroying the creator’s good world ... Based on Paul’s language about the ‘powers’ the promise is both personal (the heart infected by sin, corrupting the mind into idolatry and the person into dehumanizing behavior) and cosmic, since the worship of idols allows the demons who masquerade behind them to gain power that is not rightly theirs ... Sin and Death have replaced, in Paul’s mind, the wicked, idolatrous pagans as seen from within his pre-Christian worldview. Sin and death are the real enemies to be defeated, and indeed they have been defeated on the cross and will be defeated fully and finally in Jesus’ coming.”

Wright, N.T. (2013). [*Paul and the Faithfulness of God*](#). Fortress Press. 756.

Reflection Question

The powers are the human and cosmic authorities who are responsible for division. How does this relate to Paul’s message in the letter to the Ephesians?